

Interaction Obstructions in Einstein–Weyl Gravity: Cubic Protection, Second-Order Metric Failure, and Krein Visibility

GPT-5.6.sol* Asger Alstrup Palm†

Open-repository preprint, August 2026

Abstract

We study whether the two Lorentz-covariant free completions of scalar-free Einstein–Weyl gravity extend to the interacting theory. The positive pseudo-Hermitian completion uniformly quarter-turns the complete massive spin-2 multiplet, whereas the conventional Krein completion retains standard gravitational reality and assigns negative signature to that multiplet. We first prove a cubic-protection theorem. The exact Einstein consistent truncation implies that every tree amplitude with exactly one massive external field and otherwise massless gravitons vanishes, while the equal-mass MMM vertex has no real $1 \leftrightarrow 2$ shell. Hence the first-order positive-metric obstruction is zero.

At second order the physical process $MM \rightarrow Mh$ is open. In an independent second-order Einstein-frame formulation we compute nonzero on-shell MMM and MMh amplitudes and the exact pole-normalized massive residue $\sqrt{3}/8$, proving that the four-point amplitude is not identically zero. A complete calculation in the original fourth-order theory — including the quartic contact term, all s, t, u exchanges, the physical adjoint, and gauge and equation-of-motion checks — gives at an interior rational physical point an exact nonzero rational certificate. This complete physical branch-changing amplitude is the central new input; the surrounding auxiliary-field and pseudo-Hermitian formalisms are established tools. We prove an operator identity equating the anti-Hermitian part of the stationary second-order Born operator to the full second-order metric-deformation source on the free-energy shell. It follows that

$$\Pi_{\ker \text{ad}_{h_0}} \left[(v_2^\dagger - v_2) + \frac{1}{2} [R_1, v_1 + v_1^\dagger] \right] \neq 0.$$

The canonical analytic deformation based at the Paper-IV positive real form therefore fails at second order for the complete tree-level vertex content through quartic order.

On physical BRST cohomology, canonical second quantization of the free Krein symmetry gives the particle-number grading $J_F = (-1)^{\tilde{N}_M}$. The gravitational obstruction survives cohomology and is not null:

$$\mathcal{O}^\# = \mathcal{O}, \quad \text{Tr}(\mathcal{O}^\# \mathcal{O}) = -8\mathcal{A}_K^2 \neq 0.$$

Unlike the perfect-square scalar theory, Einstein–Weyl gravity has no nontrivial uniform abelian charge grading capable of placing the obstruction in a one-sided null ideal. The

*OpenAI model and principal programme author.

†Programme orchestrator and corresponding human contact; Honorary Professor, DTU Compute, Technical University of Denmark. asger@area9.dk.

result excludes both an analytic continuation of the canonical positive completion and the conventional massive-number grading as a null-sector probability mechanism. It does not exclude indefinite Krein evolution itself, nor nonlocal, non-factorizing, nonperturbative, or conformal-boundary completions. A later exact scalar **REDUCED-MODE** calculation also shows that the ordinary axis-compatible independent-mass regulator does not cancel its first complete final-state collinear logarithmic response. That is not a gravitational theorem and changes none of the tree-level results here; it sharpens the extra infrared/asymptotic-state input any Bateman–Turok-type gravitational completion would have to supply. A finite coherent-projector successor cancels that scalar coefficient while preserving idempotence, but it does not derive the transport dynamically and does not transfer to the gravitational BRST carrier. A subsequent exact scalar countermodel shows that CCR preservation, projector idempotence, trace preservation, and endpoint exchange symmetry still leave three endpoint parameters. The scalar $1/48$ value is compatible but not selected by those identities, sharpening rather than removing the need for an independently constructed continuum transport. The exact full off-resonant scalar composition now reduces the flat three-parameter endpoint freedom to one soft normalization on its declared three-dimensional chart, but its measured cross-Gram remains $-(1/2) dr/r$ and hence logarithmically non-trace-class. It still does not derive $1/48$ and supplies no gravitational or causal normalization.

AI authorship and computational accountability

GPT-5.6.sol developed the derivations, computational checks, claim audit, and manuscript. Asger Alstrup Palm commissioned and orchestrated the programme and is the corresponding human contact. The project is an experiment in whether a non-specialist human, using AI systems as research collaborators, can organize falsifiable computer-assisted mathematical physics. The exact status of each repository check is stated where it is used, and no check is promoted beyond its documented scope. The manuscript remains subject to expert review.

Contents

1	Introduction	4
2	Free input, conventions, and the deformation class	7
2.1	Physical one-particle spectrum	7
2.2	Two free real forms	7
2.3	Regulated physical Fock space and shell projection	7
2.4	Perturbative order and the stationary Born operator	8
2.5	Reduced amplitude, LSZ normalization, and adjoint	9
3	The external-massive-leg phase theorem	9
4	Cubic protection	10
4.1	Einstein consistent truncation	10
4.2	Equal-mass cubic kinematics	11
4.3	The complete regulated cubic shell	11

5	Independent Einstein-frame factorization rail	12
5.1	Second-order action and convention change	12
5.2	Exact three-point amplitudes	13
5.3	Complete massive-pole residue	13
6	The real physical shell	14
6.1	Open kinematics	14
6.2	Interior rational certificate	14
7	Full fourth-order calculation and the metric obstruction	15
7.1	Perturbative and bordered propagator	15
7.2	Contact and exchange decomposition	16
7.3	From covariant graphs to the stationary Born operator	16
7.4	Quarter-turn and the deformation cocycle	17
7.5	First-order metric ambiguity	17
8	Conventional Krein grading on physical cohomology	18
8.1	One-particle commutant	18
8.2	Canonical second quantization and cluster multiplicativity	19
9	Krein visibility of the obstruction	19
10	No scalar-like charge-null mechanism	20
11	BRST cohomology	21
12	Master theorem	21
13	Scope and nonclaims	22
14	Discussion	24
14.1	The same order pattern, for different reasons	24
14.2	Relation to the PT-symmetric quadratic-gravity proposal	25
14.3	Real forms become dynamical	25
14.4	Why the factorization and physical rails are both useful	25
14.5	What Krein visibility means	25
A	Einstein consistent truncation and LSZ	28
B	Einstein-frame cubic expansion	29
C	Polarization basis and factorization sum	30
D	Physical-shell geometry and the rational point	30
E	Full four-point engine and deformation certificate	31
E.1	Wave algebra	31
E.2	Exact polarization tensors	31
E.3	Gauge and adjoint checks	32

E.4 Pole regression	32
F Covariant grading and Fock-lift equations	32
G BRST block and non-nullity	33
H Machine-verification index	34

1 Introduction

Scalar-free Einstein–Weyl gravity is the simplest four-dimensional quadratic-curvature theory whose flat-space physical spectrum consists of the ordinary massless graviton and one additional massive spin-2 multiplet. In the curvature convention used here its action is

$$S[g] = \int d^4x \sqrt{-g} (c_1 R + \alpha R_{\mu\nu} R^{\mu\nu} + \beta R^2), \quad \alpha = -3\beta, \quad (1)$$

with $M^2 = c_1/\alpha > 0$ in the split phase. Up to the four-dimensional Euler density, the quadratic term is Weyl-squared. The extra spin-2 branch has the opposite kinetic sign, the familiar higher-derivative ghost of quadratic gravity [1, 2]. Neither this spectrum nor its nonlinear auxiliary-field reformulation is new: quadratic gravity was put in a local second-order Einstein–scalar–massive-tensor form by Hindawi, Ovrut, and Waldram [3], and the scalar-free massive-tensor sector was developed in detail by Magnano and Sokółowski [4].

Paper IV of this series [25] did not choose between proposed interacting cures. It classified the *free* covariant completions. After symplectic reduction, all five massive polarizations form one irreducible massive spin-2 representation. Covariance therefore allows no helicity-by-helicity compromise. There are two real-form classes in the stated free, quasifree, mode-local setting:

1. a positive pseudo-Hermitian completion in which the entire massive multiplet has quarter-turned reality; and
2. a Krein completion with standard gravitational reality, positive massless signature, and uniform negative massive signature.

They determine the same free complex spectral functional but different adjoints and probability structures. The natural interacting question is therefore sharp:

Does either covariant free completion survive the tree interaction through quartic order?

Paper V [26] supplied the deformation complex used here to ask the positive part of this question. Perturbative pseudo-Hermitian metrics, their homogeneous ambiguities, and interacting field-theory constructions have a substantial prior literature [6, 7]; we do not claim the order-by-order formalism itself as new. If ρ_0 is the free Dyson map and v_n are the transported interaction vertices, an analytic correction $\rho_\zeta = \exp[-\frac{1}{2} \sum_n \zeta^n R_n] \rho_0$ must solve

$$\begin{aligned} [h_0, R_1] &= v_1^\dagger - v_1, \\ [h_0, R_2] &= (v_2^\dagger - v_2) + \frac{1}{2}[R_1, v_1 + v_1^\dagger]. \end{aligned} \quad (2)$$

On a degenerate free-energy shell the right-hand side must have zero projection onto $\ker \text{ad}_{h_0}$. That shell projection is the metric obstruction. In the perfect-square scalar, first-order protection was followed by a second-order branch-changing obstruction; at the exact massless $O(1,1)$ boundary, however, the offending component could become one-sided in continuous charge and null in the generalized Born trace.

Prior amplitudes and the precise novelty claim. The geometric premise behind the cubic selection rule is also known: Einstein metrics form an exact Bach-flat subsector. Related amplitude work proves that Ricci-curvature deformations leave all-Einstein-graviton tree amplitudes unchanged and that the corresponding pure conformal amplitudes vanish [5]. Lemma 4.1 below is the mass-eigenfield, one-massive-leg consequence of that established consistent truncation, not a new discovery of the Einstein subsector. Conformal-gravity BRST/LSZ quantization and its indefinite scattering problem have likewise been studied directly [8], and conformal or mass-deformed ghost-state amplitudes are known in adjacent conformal and supersymmetric theories [10, 11]. Those works concern the conformal/Jordan phase or different amplitude sectors, not the regular split-phase process studied here.

The closest comparison is Kuntz’s PT-symmetric quadratic-gravity proposal [9]. It uses the same scalar-free quadratic action and, up to convention, the same complex rotation of the complete massive spin-2 field. It constructs the free BRST physical subspace and solves an interacting pseudo-Hermitian metric in a mode-truncated Hamiltonian in which spin and momentum labels and the exact gravitational vertex coefficients are suppressed. It does not evaluate a complete degenerate physical scattering shell. The calculation below supplies precisely that missing stress test.

To our knowledge, the narrow new input of this paper is the first complete exact calculation of the physical mass-eigenfield process $MM \rightarrow Mh$ in scalar-free Einstein–Weyl gravity, together with its independent complete massive-pole residue, and the use of that physical block to produce an explicit metric-deformation cocycle. The novelty is the verified gravitational source, not the auxiliary formulation, the general deformation equations, the elementary external-leg phase count, or indefinite-metric algebra. Propositions 2.1 and 7.1 make the amplitude-to-cocycle step an operator identity rather than a phase-based inference.

Gravity has the same perturbative-order pattern and a different mechanism:

$$\boxed{\mathfrak{o}_+^{(1)} = 0, \quad \mathfrak{o}_+^{(2)} \neq 0.} \tag{3}$$

The cubic protection follows from the exact Einstein subsector together with equal-mass kinematics. The second-order obstruction is carried by the physically open process

$$M + M \longrightarrow M + h, \tag{4}$$

which changes massive particle number by one. The same process also separates gravity from the scalar boundary mechanism. Covariance and the free signature fix the one-particle symmetry; its natural particle-number-diagonal, cluster-multiplicative lift is $(-1)^{N_M}$. But $\mathbb{Z}_2$ -odd does not imply null: the product of two odd operators is neutral and its quadratic trace is nonzero.

Results. The proof has four independent layers.

1. Section 3 proves a diagram-level phase theorem: a connected amplitude with E_M external massive legs changes by $(-i)^{E_M}$ under the uniform quarter-turn, including the compensating sign of every internal massive propagator.
2. Section 4 proves cubic protection. The Einstein consistent truncation kills Mhh , while MMM has no real physical $1 \leftrightarrow 2$ shell.
3. Sections 5–7 prove the second-order obstruction twice: first by an independent nonzero Einstein-frame factorization residue, then by a complete exact physical four-point calculation in the original fourth-order theory, joined to the deformation complex by Proposition 2.1.
4. Sections 8–11 prove conventional Krein visibility: the canonical multiplicative Fock lift is fixed in the stated class, the exact block is not null, no scalar-like abelian charge exists, and the block is not BRST-exact on physical cohomology.

Comparison with the scalar obstruction. The parallel and the difference are summarized by

Perfect-square scalar	Einstein–Weyl gravity
Källén zero and reality-factor protection	Einstein consistent truncation and equal-mass kinematics
$H + L \rightarrow L + L$	$M + M \rightarrow M + h$
$O(1, 1)$ one-sided null ideal at the exact boundary	no nontrivial uniform abelian charge grading
obstruction can become probability-invisible	obstruction remains non-null for the conventional covariant Krein form

Strength of the claims. “Metric failure” means failure of the analytic order-by-order deformation of the canonical covariant positive free metric in the operator class of (2). It is not an absolute theorem against every positive metric, and no complex interacting spectrum is proved. “Krein visibility” has the precise finite-block meaning $\mathcal{O}^\sharp \mathcal{O} \neq 0$ and $\text{Tr}(\mathcal{O}^\sharp \mathcal{O}) \neq 0$ for the canonical particle-number-diagonal, cluster-multiplicative grading. It is a non-nullity statement, not a claim that an indefinite trace is a positive probability. In particular, the paper does not rule out an indefinite Krein dynamics; it rules out the naive parity/null-sector mechanism as a replacement for a positive interacting probability calculus.

Verification. The labels G13–G18 denote entries in the machine-verification ledger of Appendix H; they are not additional assumptions or mathematical objects. The checks use exact SymPy or rational arithmetic. The exhaustive $5^3 \times 2$ polarization scan once proposed as G16 is not used: the factorization residue, exact real-shell certificate, crossing, Ward, and gauge checks already close the proof. The scan remains optional regression hardening.

2 Free input, conventions, and the deformation class

2.1 Physical one-particle spectrum

We use signature $(+, -, -, -)$ in the main text. Around flat space the reduced physical one-particle space is

$$\mathcal{H}_{\text{phys}}^{(1)} = \mathcal{H}_{h,+2} \oplus \mathcal{H}_{h,-2} \oplus \mathcal{H}_M, \quad \dim \mathcal{H}_M = 5. \quad (5)$$

The massless summands carry helicities ± 2 on $p^2 = 0$; the massive summand carries the spin-2 representation on $p^2 = M^2$. Paper IV derives this by explicit diffeomorphism reduction rather than by a covariant propagator count. Its result is a healthy massless sector and a uniformly ghost-signed massive sector.

2.2 Two free real forms

In the positive class the original massive mass eigenfield is $\ddagger$ -anti-Hermitian. We write the positive-frame observable as

$$\widehat{M}_{\mu\nu} = iM_{\mu\nu}, \quad M_{\mu\nu} = -i\widehat{M}_{\mu\nu}. \quad (6)$$

The same quarter-turn acts on every one of the five polarizations. The massless graviton retains standard reality. In the conventional Krein class both fields retain standard gravitational reality, while the one-particle fundamental symmetry has signature

$$J_{\text{free}}^{(1)} = I_2 \oplus (-I_5), \quad \text{signature } (+, +; -, -, -, -, -). \quad (7)$$

The uniformity is not optional. Since $\mathcal{H}_M$ is an irreducible massive spin-2 representation, Schur's lemma makes every covariant Hermitian form on its fiber a scalar multiple of the identity. Rotating only selected helicities would violate Lorentz covariance [25].

2.3 Regulated physical Fock space and shell projection

As in Paper V, the cohomological equation is first interpreted in a periodic spatial box. We retain finitely many nonzero momentum modes, impose an ultraviolet and a finite-particle cutoff, and omit the massless zero mode. Normal ordering removes vacuum contractions, and we work with connected transition kernels. On this regulated physical Fock space h_0 has point spectrum with finite-rank eigenspaces. If P_E projects onto free energy E , then

$$\Pi_{\ker \text{ad}_{h_0}} S = \sum_E P_E S P_E, \quad (8)$$

and $[h_0, R] = S$ has a solution only if this projection vanishes.

The rational point used below lies on the momentum lattice whenever $ML/(2\pi)$ is a multiple of 100. The ultraviolet cutoff may be chosen above every external and internal momentum occurring in the calculation. We take a sequence of such boxes after establishing the finite-volume obstruction. Omitting the zero mode is the infrared prescription; the exhibited momenta remain uniformly nonsoft along this sequence. Thus neither the matrix element nor its internal denominators depends on a soft limiting prescription.

2.4 Perturbative order and the stationary Born operator

Introduce a formal coupling ζ by assigning the cubic expansion of the Einstein–Weyl action order ζ and its quartic expansion order ζ^2 . After the Paper-IV free Dyson map, write

$$H_+(\zeta) = h_0 + \zeta v_1 + \zeta^2 v_2 + O(\zeta^3). \quad (9)$$

The second-order metric-deformation source is

$$S_2 = (v_2^\dagger - v_2) + \frac{1}{2}[R_1, v_1 + v_1^\dagger], \quad [h_0, R_1] = v_1^\dagger - v_1. \quad (10)$$

This is the meaning of “second order” throughout the paper: one quartic vertex or two cubic vertices at tree level.

Set $Q_E = 1 - P_E$ and define the self-adjoint reduced resolvent

$$G_E = Q_E(E - h_0)^{-1}Q_E. \quad (11)$$

The stationary connected second-order Born operator on the shell is

$$\mathcal{B}_{2,+}(E) = P_E(v_2 + v_1 G_E v_1)P_E. \quad (12)$$

At finite volume no $i0$ is required. In the continuum notation G_E is the principal-value part of $(E - h_0 + i0)^{-1}$. The possible $-i\pi\delta(E - h_0)$ contribution is absent here because the regulated physical cubic shell is empty; Lemma 4.2 below makes this statement on the complete Fock eigenspace, including spectators.

Proposition 2.1 (Born–deformation identity). *Suppose $P_E v_1 P_E = 0$ and choose the canonical off-shell solution of the first equation in (10),*

$$R_1^{(0)} = \sum_{E_a \neq E_b} \frac{P_{E_a}(v_1^\dagger - v_1)P_{E_b}}{E_a - E_b}. \quad (13)$$

Then the entire second-order metric source, not only its quartic part, satisfies

$$\boxed{P_E S_2 P_E = \mathcal{B}_{2,+}(E)^\dagger - \mathcal{B}_{2,+}(E)}. \quad (14)$$

Consequently, a nonzero ordinary-adjoint anti-Hermitian Born matrix element on the shell is a nonzero metric-deformation cocycle.

Proof. Write $D = v_1^\dagger - v_1$ and $W = v_1 + v_1^\dagger$. The spectral formula (13) gives

$$P_E R_1^{(0)} Q_E = P_E D G_E, \quad Q_E R_1^{(0)} P_E = -G_E D P_E. \quad (15)$$

Since $P_E v_1 P_E = 0$, insertion of Q_E between the two cubic vertices is automatic. Hence

$$\begin{aligned} \frac{1}{2}P_E[R_1^{(0)}, W]P_E &= \frac{1}{2}P_E(DG_E W + WG_E D)P_E \\ &= P_E(v_1^\dagger G_E v_1^\dagger - v_1 G_E v_1)P_E. \end{aligned} \quad (16)$$

Adding $P_E(v_2^\dagger - v_2)P_E$ gives (14), because $G_E = G_E^\dagger$. Thus the quartic contact and the two-cubic exchange contribution enter with exactly the relative combination required by the deformation equation. $\square$

Remark 2.2 (Contact, exchange, and the logical bridge). The two terms in the deformation source now have a fixed diagrammatic meaning. The shell projection of $v_2^\dagger - v_2$ is the anti-Hermitian difference of the canonical quartic vertex, including the instantaneous terms generated by the Legendre transform. Equation (16) is the anti-Hermitian difference of the complete two-cubic intermediate-state sum. Their sum, and only their sum, is the connected second-order Born block. Thus the later four-point amplitude is not being substituted for S_2 on the basis of its external-leg phase: Proposition 7.1 first identifies the complete covariant contact-plus-exchange calculation with (12), and (14) then identifies its anti-Hermitian part with $P_E S_2 P_E$. The finite-volume principal-value prescription, external normalizations, identical-particle factors, and removal of disconnected pieces are stated separately below.

2.5 Reduced amplitude, LSZ normalization, and adjoint

The perturbiner strips the universal Feynman i from the multilinear action coefficient; denote the result by $\mathcal{A}_K^{\text{red}}$. At real momenta and real linear polarizations it is real. Let $|i\rangle, |f\rangle$ be unit-normalized finite-volume asymptotic states. Matching the covariant tree expansion to the stationary Born series gives

$$\langle f | \mathcal{B}_{2,K}(E) | i \rangle = \mathcal{A}_K = \eta_{\text{conv}} \mathcal{N}_{fi} \mathcal{A}_K^{\text{red}}, \quad \eta_{\text{conv}} \in \{\pm 1\}, \quad \mathcal{N}_{fi} > 0. \quad (17)$$

After removing the overall momentum-conservation Kronecker delta, $\mathcal{N}_{fi}$ is the product of the nonzero external pole residues, $(2\omega L^3)^{-1/2}$ factors, polarization normalizations, and Bose normalizations. At the displayed point the two incoming massive momenta are distinct, so their identical-particle factor is one; the outgoing particles have different species. The multilinear wave labels already implement the vertex symmetry factors. The real sign η_{conv} fixes the convention relating the interaction Hamiltonian to the Lagrangian Feynman rule.

Equation (17) also explains why stripping the universal Feynman i does not manufacture the obstruction: the removed factor is common to forward and reverse S -matrix elements, whereas the anti-Hermitian phase below comes from the three massive quarter-turns. Real, nonzero LSZ and normalization factors cannot change that phase or the nonvanishing result. Exact rational values are quoted for $\mathcal{A}_K^{\text{red}}$; operator and trace statements use the normalized coefficient $\mathcal{A}_K$.

3 The external-massive-leg phase theorem

The quarter-turn phase must be transported through complete diagrams, not appended to an already computed external state by slogan. Internal massive lines carry the compensating kinetic sign.

Theorem 3.1 (External-massive-leg phase). *Let $\mathcal{D}$ be a connected perturbative diagram written in mass-eigenfields (h, M) , with E_M external massive legs and I_M internal massive lines. Under (6), its complete reduced amplitude obeys*

$$\mathcal{A}_+^{(E_M)}(\mathcal{D}) = (-i)^{E_M} \mathcal{A}_K^{(E_M)}(\mathcal{D}). \quad (18)$$

The statement includes contact terms, exchanges, and the sign of each massive inverse kernel.

Proof. Let n_v be the number of massive fields incident at vertex v . Field substitution contributes

$$\prod_v (-i)^{n_v}. \quad (19)$$

The massive quadratic form changes sign because $(-i)^2 = -1$; hence its inverse, the internal massive propagator, also contributes -1 per internal massive line. Every internal massive line is incident twice, so

$$\sum_v n_v = E_M + 2I_M. \quad (20)$$

The total factor is therefore

$$(-i)^{E_M+2I_M} (-1)^{I_M} = (-i)^{E_M} (-1)^{I_M} (-1)^{I_M} = (-i)^{E_M}. \quad (21)$$

Massless propagators are unchanged. Since the argument is diagramwise, it applies to their complete sum. Local invertible changes between regular mass-eigenfield frames can redistribute contact and exchange terms but leave the on-shell statement unchanged. $\square$

Corollary 3.2 (Phase selection). *For a real standard-frame tree amplitude, even E_M gives a real positive-frame coefficient and odd E_M gives a purely imaginary one. Only odd- E_M processes can contribute to the ordinary-adjoint anti-Hermitian shell source.*

For the four-point process (4), $E_M = 3$, and

$$\mathcal{A}_+ = i\mathcal{A}_K. \quad (22)$$

The sign is tied to the convention $M = -i\widehat{M}$; reversing the quarter-turn reverses the displayed sign but not the obstruction's nonvanishing.

4 Cubic protection

There are two odd-massive cubic structures: Mhh and MMM . The first is eliminated dynamically, the second kinematically.

4.1 Einstein consistent truncation

The scalar-free equations may be written schematically as

$$c_1 G_{\mu\nu} + \gamma_B B_{\mu\nu} = 0, \quad (23)$$

where $B_{\mu\nu}$ is the Bach tensor and γ_B depends on the normalization in (1). Every Ricci-flat Einstein metric has $G_{\mu\nu} = 0$ and is Bach-flat. More generally Einstein metrics are Bach-flat [14]. Thus the nonlinear Einstein solution space is an exact subsector of the Einstein–Weyl equations.

On the regular split branch, the higher-derivative theory admits a local second-order mass-eigenfield formulation in which the Einstein metric and the nonlinear massive spin-2 field are separate variables [4]. Denote them by (h, M) near flat space. The field map is algebraic and locally invertible on this branch, and $M = 0$ is precisely the Einstein subsector. These hypotheses are what make the following LSZ statement stronger than a basis-dependent observation.

Lemma 4.1 (One-massive-leg rule). *For asymptotic mass eigenfields on the regular split branch,*

$$\mathcal{A}_{\text{tree}}(M, h, \dots, h) = 0. \quad (24)$$

In particular $\mathcal{A}_3(Mhh) = 0$ for every physical polarization.

Proof. Write the massive-field equation in the second-order frame as

$$\mathcal{K}_M M + J_M^{(2)}[h, h] + J_M^{(3)}[h, h, h] + \dots = 0. \quad (25)$$

For every nonlinear vacuum Einstein solution h_E , the pair $(h_E, M = 0)$ solves the full theory. Hence the terms independent of M vanish on the Einstein graviton shell. Functional differentiation and LSZ reduction say that a physical amplitude with one external M and all remaining external legs in the Einstein subsector is zero. Terms generated by a local invertible change of fields are proportional to equations of motion or external inverse propagators and vanish under LSZ, the standard equivalence-theorem mechanism [15]. $\square$

The exact perturbative check evaluates the physical decay point with the massive particle at rest and two back-to-back massless gravitons. All $5 \times 4 = 20$ combinations of the five massive polarizations and four graviton-helicity choices vanish exactly. This is a check of the amplitude-level content of Lemma 4.1, not its only justification.

4.2 Equal-mass cubic kinematics

The MMM vertex itself is nonzero at complex on-shell kinematics (Section 5). It nevertheless has no real physical $1 \leftrightarrow 2$ shell. If $p_3 = p_1 + p_2$ with future-directed $p_i^2 = M^2$, then

$$p_3^2 = (p_1 + p_2)^2 \geq (2M)^2, \quad (26)$$

which cannot equal M^2 . Equivalently, a particle of mass M cannot decay into two particles of the same mass.

4.3 The complete regulated cubic shell

The Born-deformation identity requires a statement about the complete degenerate eigenspace, not only the two states later used to display the four-point obstruction.

Lemma 4.2 (Vanishing of the regulated physical cubic shell). *On the regulated physical Fock space of Section 2, with the massless zero mode omitted,*

$$P_E v_1 P_E = P_E v_1^\dagger P_E = 0 \quad (27)$$

for every free energy E . The statement includes disconnected spectators: the connected cubic vertex cannot act nontrivially inside a degenerate many-particle shell.

Proof. A normal-ordered cubic matrix element is an active $0 \leftrightarrow 3$ or $1 \leftrightarrow 2$ process times Kronecker deltas for particles on which the vertex does not act. Positive energy forbids $0 \leftrightarrow 3$. It remains to classify the four physical cubic field contents. The Mhh amplitude is zero by Lemma 4.1; MMM is closed by equal-mass kinematics. For MMh , the channel $h \rightarrow MM$ would require $k^2 = (p_1 + p_2)^2 \geq 4M^2$, while $M \rightarrow M + h$ would require $p_M \cdot k = 0$ for a future

timelike p_M and a future nonzero null k , which is impossible. The only limiting exception is $k = 0$, removed by the infrared prescription. Finally, real on-shell hhh kinematics is collinear, and the physical Einstein three-graviton amplitude vanishes there. Spectators do not alter any active momentum or energy equation, so they multiply these zeros. Taking the adjoint gives the second equality in (27). $\square$

Theorem 4.3 (Cubic protection). *For scalar-free Einstein–Weyl gravity about flat space, the Lorentz-covariant positive real form has no first-order physical on-shell metric obstruction:*

$$\boxed{\mathfrak{o}_+^{(1)} = 0.} \quad (28)$$

Proof. By Corollary 3.2, only odd-massive cubic amplitudes can enter $\Pi_{\ker \text{ad}_{h_0}}(v_1^\dagger - v_1)$. The Mhh amplitude vanishes by Lemma 4.1; the MMM amplitude has no real physical shell. The remaining cubic structures carry an even number of massive legs. Equivalently, the stronger Lemma 4.2 makes the complete first-order shell block vanish. $\square$

This protection is structurally different from the Källén-factor zero of Paper V. It is a consequence of an exact nonlinear consistent truncation plus massive-particle kinematics.

5 Independent Einstein-frame factorization rail

The next odd-massive process is four-point $MM \rightarrow Mh$. Before expanding the original fourth-order action to quartic order, we prove independently that this amplitude is not identically zero.

5.1 Second-order action and convention change

This section follows the exact Einstein-frame formulation of Magnano and Sokolowski [4]. Its verification artifact uses signature $(-, +, +, +)$, only in this section and Appendix B; thus a massive pole is $P^2 = -M^2$. With $M = 1$ and in the notation of that formulation, the nonlinear massive-field Lagrangian is

$$L_M = \frac{1}{2}K(Q) + \frac{m^2}{8A}(-\tau^2 + \psi_{\mu\nu}\psi^{\mu\nu} + 6A\tau - 12A^2), \quad \psi = g + \Phi. \quad (29)$$

Here $Q^\alpha{}_{\mu\nu} = \Gamma^\alpha{}_{\mu\nu}(\psi) - \Gamma^\alpha{}_{\mu\nu}(g)$,

$$K(Q) = g^{\mu\nu} \left(Q^\alpha{}_{\mu\nu} Q^\beta{}_{\alpha\beta} - Q^\alpha{}_{\mu\beta} Q^\beta{}_{\nu\alpha} \right), \quad (30)$$

A is the determinant ratio and τ the corresponding trace defined in [4]. The form (29) separates Einstein gravity from a minimally coupled nonlinear massive spin-2 field.

For linearly traceless external fields, the determinant and inverse-determinant contributions to the apparent $\text{tr } \Phi^3$ potential cancel exactly:

$$V(\Phi) = \frac{m^2}{8} \text{tr } \Phi^2 + O(\Phi^4). \quad (31)$$

The nonzero MMM amplitude below comes entirely from $K(Q)$.

5.2 Exact three-point amplitudes

Take all momenta incoming. For the MMM vertex use

$$P = (1, 0, 0, 0), \quad p = \left(-\frac{1}{2}, 0, 0, \frac{i\sqrt{3}}{2}\right), \quad q = \left(-\frac{1}{2}, 0, 0, -\frac{i\sqrt{3}}{2}\right). \quad (32)$$

Then $P + p + q = 0$ and $P^2 = p^2 = q^2 = -1$. With normalized TT polarizations (M_+, M_+, M_0) , direct expansion of (29) gives

$$\boxed{\mathcal{A}_3(M_+, M_+, M_0) = -\frac{\sqrt{6}}{8}.} \quad (33)$$

For MMh , take

$$-P = (-1, 0, 0, 0), \quad r = (1, -1, -i, 0), \quad k = (0, 1, i, 0), \quad (34)$$

so $-P + r + k = 0$, $r^2 = -1$, and $k^2 = 0$. For the polarization choice in Appendix B,

$$\boxed{\mathcal{A}_3(M_+, M, h) = -\frac{\sqrt{2}}{8}.} \quad (35)$$

The graviton Ward identity vanishes for an arbitrary symbolic vector ξ_μ under $\varepsilon_{\mu\nu}^h \mapsto k_{(\mu}\xi_{\nu)}$, and exchange of the two massive legs leaves the coefficient unchanged.

5.3 Complete massive-pole residue

Glue (33) and (35) across P . A complete orthonormal rest-frame basis contains the polarizations $+, \times, 0, xz, yz$. The exact products are

λ	$\mathcal{A}_{MMM}$	$\mathcal{A}_{MMh}$	product
$+$	$-\sqrt{6}/8$	$-\sqrt{2}/8$	$\sqrt{3}/32$
$\times$	0	0	0
0	0	$\sqrt{6}/8$	0
xz	0	0	0
yz	0	$i\sqrt{2}/4$	0

Therefore the complete polarization numerator is

$$N = \sum_{\lambda=1}^5 \mathcal{A}_3(M, M, M_P^\lambda) \mathcal{A}_3(M_{-P}^\lambda, M, h) = \frac{\sqrt{3}}{32}. \quad (36)$$

The TT inverse kernel in the same action convention is

$$K_M(P) = \frac{P^2 + M^2}{4}. \quad (37)$$

Consequently

$$\boxed{\text{Res}_{P^2=-M^2} \mathcal{A}_4(M, M, M, h) = \frac{\sqrt{3}}{8} \neq 0.} \quad (38)$$

An overall rescaling of the action rescales the displayed residue but not its nonvanishing. A local quartic contact term is regular at this pole and cannot cancel it.

Proposition 5.1 (Factorization nonvanishing). *The tree-level four-point amplitude tensor for $MM \rightarrow Mh$ is not identically zero on the relevant complexified on-shell component.*

Proof. If the rational amplitude vanished identically, every factorization residue would vanish. Equation (38) is the complete massive-polarization residue and is nonzero. $\square$

6 The real physical shell

6.1 Open kinematics

In the center-of-mass frame, with signature $(+, -, -, -)$ restored,

$$|\mathbf{k}| = \frac{s - M^2}{2\sqrt{s}}, \quad E_{M,\text{out}} = \frac{s + M^2}{2\sqrt{s}}, \quad s \geq 4M^2. \quad (39)$$

Thus $MM \rightarrow Mh$ is physically open on a continuum shell, unlike the cubic MMM channel.

Lemma 6.1 (Complex nonvanishing and a real component). *Fix analytic physical polarization sections on an irreducible component of the complexified four-point mass shell. The nonsingular real $MM \rightarrow Mh$ region contains a Euclidean-open center-of-mass chart and is Zariski dense in the complex component containing it. Hence a rational tree amplitude that vanishes on an open real subset vanishes identically on that component and has zero factorization residues.*

Proof. Away from exceptional polarization charts, the real physical region is parametrized by $s > 4M^2$, $-1 < \cos \theta < 1$, and an azimuth. Its real points contain an open set of maximal real dimension in the relevant algebraic component. If $\mathcal{A} = P/Q$ is regular there and vanishes on a real open set, real analyticity makes P vanish there. The identity theorem, equivalently Zariski density of that real locus, makes P vanish on the component. Then all residues vanish, contrary to (38). $\square$

The next subsection supplies a stronger direct bridge: an exact nonzero point already on the real shell. It makes Lemma 6.1 logically redundant for the obstruction theorem, while retaining it as an independent explanation of why the complex factorization rail is physically relevant.

6.2 Interior rational certificate

Set $M = 1$. With p_1, p_2 incoming and p_3, k outgoing, take

$$\begin{aligned} p_1 &= \left(\frac{5}{4}, 0, 0, \frac{3}{4} \right), & p_2 &= \left(\frac{5}{4}, 0, 0, -\frac{3}{4} \right), \\ p_3 &= \left(\frac{29}{20}, -\frac{21}{25}, 0, -\frac{63}{100} \right), & k &= \left(\frac{21}{20}, \frac{21}{25}, 0, \frac{63}{100} \right). \end{aligned} \quad (40)$$

Then

$$p_1 + p_2 = p_3 + k, \quad p_i^2 = 1, \quad k^2 = 0, \quad (41)$$

and

$$s = \frac{25}{4}M^2, \quad \cos \theta = \frac{3}{5}. \quad (42)$$

This point is interior and noncollinear. The planar kinematics has a y -reflection selection rule; the verification therefore uses explicit parity-even real linear polarizations rather than interpreting symmetry zeros as dynamical cancellations.

Computational Proposition 6.2 (Exact real-shell certificate). *For the real polarization tensors listed in Appendix E, the complete reduced tree amplitude at (40) is*

$$\boxed{\mathcal{A}_K^{\text{red}}(MM \rightarrow Mh) = \frac{7881241032}{5584765625} \neq 0.} \quad (43)$$

It is real and nonsingular. The complete sum passes an exact Ward test for a rational gauge vector, invariance under an exact rational change of gauge representative, and equality between axial and de Donder internal gauges. Hence both $\mathcal{A}_K^{\text{red}}$ and its normalized Born coefficient $\mathcal{A}_K$ are nonzero on a physical-shell neighborhood.

7 Full fourth-order calculation and the metric obstruction

The calculation of Proposition 6.2 is performed directly in the original fourth-order variables of (1), independently of the Einstein-frame factorization rail.

7.1 Perturbiner and bordered propagator

For four plane waves,

$$g_{\mu\nu} = \eta_{\mu\nu} + \sum_{a=1}^4 \lambda_a \varepsilon_{\mu\nu}^{(a)} e^{ip_a \cdot x}, \quad (44)$$

the wave algebra retains only multilinear subsets of the labels and implements $\partial_\mu \mapsto iP_\mu$ automatically. The coefficient of $\lambda_1 \lambda_2 \lambda_3 \lambda_4$ in the action gives the exact quartic contact. The same engine produces the quadratic 10×10 operator $K(P)$ and cubic current J_A in the symmetric-tensor basis.

No symbolic closed propagator is assumed. In each s, t, u channel one solves the exact de Donder-bordered system

$$\begin{pmatrix} K(P) & C(P)^T \\ C(P) & 0 \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} X \\ \lambda \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} -J^{(cd)} \\ 0 \end{pmatrix}, \quad \mathcal{A}_{\text{exch}} = J^{(ab)T} X, \quad (45)$$

where

$$C_\mu(X) = P^\alpha X_{\alpha\mu} - \frac{1}{2} P_\mu X^\alpha{}_\alpha. \quad (46)$$

The exact field-equation residual and CX vanish in all three channels. Replacing C by the axial constraint $n^\mu X_{\mu\nu} = 0$ leaves the total amplitude unchanged.

7.2 Contact and exchange decomposition

At the rational point and polarization choice, the four contributions are

$$\begin{aligned}\mathcal{A}_{\text{contact}} &= \frac{8364585636057}{410644531250}, \\ \mathcal{A}_s &= -\frac{836906329}{45312500}, \\ \mathcal{A}_t &= -\frac{5142800561}{111695312500}, \\ \mathcal{A}_u &= -\frac{90855828716}{205322265625}.\end{aligned}\tag{47}$$

Their exact sum is (43). The contact term alone is not gauge invariant. Replacing the external graviton by $k_{(\mu}\xi_{\nu)}$ makes the *complete* contact-plus-exchange sum vanish for an arbitrary exact rational test vector; shifting a physical representative by the same gauge tensor leaves the amplitude unchanged. Initial-massive Bose exchange is exact. The two-point coefficient against every symmetric-tensor basis direction vanishes for each external on-shell polarization, excluding equation-of-motion contamination.

Reversing all external momenta and conjugating the real polarization sections reproduces the contact and each exchange separately. The quadratic kernels are recomputed and satisfy $K(-P) = K(P)$ exactly. Thus the reverse process entering the physical adjoint is evaluated, not inferred.

7.3 From covariant graphs to the stationary Born operator

The perturbiner is a covariant Lagrangian calculation, whereas Proposition 2.1 is stated for the canonical stationary Born operator. The following standard tree-level reduction makes their relation explicit.

Proposition 7.1 (Covariant–stationary matching). *For physical external states at (40), the complete contact-plus-exchange coefficient computed above obeys*

$$\langle f | \mathcal{B}_{2,K}(E) | i \rangle = \eta_{\text{conv}} \mathcal{N}_{fi} \mathcal{A}_K^{\text{red}} = \mathcal{A}_K \neq 0,\tag{48}$$

where $\mathcal{B}_{2,K}$ is the standard-real-form version of (12). The same identity holds for the reverse matrix element. No absorptive or prescription-dependent term occurs.

Proof. Pass to a gauge-fixed canonical formulation, equivalently to the regular second-order auxiliary-field form on the split branch. The stationary transition operator satisfies the Lippmann–Schwinger expansion

$$\mathcal{B}_K(E) = V_K + V_K(E - h_0 + i0)^{-1} \mathcal{B}_K(E),\tag{49}$$

whose order- ζ^2 coefficient is $v_{2,K} + v_{1,K} G_E v_{1,K}$. For each physical mass eigenmode, decomposing the covariant internal propagator as

$$\frac{1}{(P^0)^2 - \omega_\lambda^2 + i0} = \frac{1}{2\omega_\lambda} \left(\frac{1}{P^0 - \omega_\lambda + i0} - \frac{1}{P^0 + \omega_\lambda - i0} \right)\tag{50}$$

turns its two terms into the two old-fashioned time orderings and their $E - E_n$ denominators. Summing the complete physical polarization residues gives the intermediate-state sum in

$v_{1,K}G_E v_{1,K}$, including the massive residue sign. The s, t, u graphs exhaust that sum at four points.

For a derivative or constrained theory, the canonical Legendre transform can redistribute instantaneous and seagull terms between “contact” and “exchange.” Their sum is invariant: the canonical quartic matrix element plus its instantaneous pieces is precisely the four-wave contact coefficient after the complementary pieces from (50) are included. We therefore identify only the complete sum, not the individual gauge-dependent pieces, with the Born operator. This is the usual equivalence of covariant and old-fashioned tree perturbation theory [16]; local mass-eigenfield changes preserve its on-shell matrix element by the equivalence theorem [15].

At the rational point all three bordered internal systems are nonsingular, and Lemma 4.2 excludes an on-shell cubic intermediate state. Thus $i0$ in (50) reduces to the real principal-value resolvent (11). The external pole residues, box factors, polarization norms and Bose factors give exactly the real nonzero multiplier in (17). The separately evaluated reverse graphs give the ordinary-adjoint reverse matrix element with the same multiplier. $\square$

7.4 Quarter-turn and the deformation cocycle

For the contact, three external massive fields give $(-i)^3 = i$. An exchange through an internal massless line has endpoint phase $(-i)^2(-i) = i$. An exchange through an internal massive line has endpoint phase $(-i)^3(-i)^2 = -i$, while the quarter-turned massive inverse kernel contributes -1 , again giving i . Consequently every piece of (47) obeys Theorem 3.1, and

$$\langle Mh | \mathcal{B}_{2,+}(E) | MM \rangle = i\mathcal{A}_K, \quad \langle MM | \mathcal{B}_{2,+}(E) | Mh \rangle = i\mathcal{A}_K. \quad (51)$$

Both states have exact free energy

$$E_{MM} = \frac{5}{4} + \frac{5}{4} = \frac{5}{2} = \frac{29}{20} + \frac{21}{20} = E_{Mh}. \quad (52)$$

Let $P_i = |MM\rangle\langle MM|$, $P_f = |Mh\rangle\langle Mh|$, and $\text{Off}_{if}(X) = P_f X P_i + P_i X P_f$. On the ordered orthonormal basis $(|MM\rangle, |Mh\rangle)$,

$$\text{Off}_{if} \mathcal{B}_{2,+}(E) = i\mathcal{A}_K \sigma_x, \quad (53)$$

and hence

$$\boxed{\text{Off}_{if}(P_E S_2 P_E) = -2i\mathcal{A}_K \sigma_x \neq 0.} \quad (54)$$

In the reduced external-leg convention, the exact certificate is

$$(\eta_{\text{conv}} \mathcal{N}_{fi})^{-1} \text{Off}_{if}(P_E S_2 P_E) = -\frac{15762482064}{5584765625} i \sigma_x. \quad (55)$$

Equations (54) and (55) now follow from the deformation-complex identity (14), rather than from an external-leg phase argument alone.

7.5 First-order metric ambiguity

The solution $R_1^{(0)}$ in (13) is defined up to a Hermitian G with $[G, h_0] = 0$. Such a change shifts the second-order source by $\frac{1}{2}[G, v_1 + v_1^\dagger]$. The complete regulated Fock-space statement in Lemma 4.2 gives

$$P_E(v_1 + v_1^\dagger)P_E = 0, \quad P_E[G, v_1 + v_1^\dagger]P_E = 0. \quad (56)$$

Indeed, $[G, h_0] = 0$ makes G block diagonal in the P_E decomposition, so the second equality is the commutator of $P_E G P_E$ with the first zero block. Disconnected spectators and soft configurations have already been covered by the lemma's regulated Fock-space statement. The obstruction cannot be moved or canceled by choosing another analytic first-order metric representative.

Theorem 7.2 (Second-order positive-metric obstruction). *The canonical analytic metric deformation based at the Paper-IV Lorentz-covariant positive real form admits no second-order solution for the complete Einstein–Weyl tree-level cubic and quartic vertex content. The obstruction is nonzero on the physical $MM \rightarrow Mh$ shell at (40) and on a nonempty open neighborhood of that point.*

Proof. Propositions 2.1 and 7.1 turn the exact four-point calculation into the nonzero source (54) in $\ker \text{ad}_{h_0}$. No R_2 can have a commutator with h_0 equal to that source. Equation (56) makes the class independent of the homogeneous first-order metric freedom. The Ward, external-EOM, reverse-process, internal-gauge and LSZ arguments show that the displayed matrix element lies on the reduced physical shell. Real analyticity extends its nonvanishing from the interior point to an open neighborhood. $\square$

8 Conventional Krein grading on physical cohomology

The positive obstruction does not by itself decide whether an indefinite completion can still be formulated. The narrower question addressed here is whether the conventional gravitational Krein grading can render the offending block null, as a continuous one-sided charge does at the perfect-square scalar boundary.

8.1 One-particle commutant

Let $J^{(1)}$ be a nondegenerate Hermitian involution on the physical one-particle cohomology (5). We require it to commute with the proper-orthochronous Poincaré representation and to agree with the free Krein real form of Paper IV.

The mass Casimir separates the massless and massive orbits, so no covariant endomorphism mixes $\mathcal{H}_h$ and $\mathcal{H}_M$. On the massive fiber, the exact spin-2 $SO(3)$ commutant is one-dimensional. There is one precision on the massless fiber: under the proper-orthochronous group, helicity +2 and helicity −2 are inequivalent complex representations, so covariance alone permits separate scalars. The complete commutant is therefore

$$J^{(1)} = \epsilon_+ I_{+2} \oplus \epsilon_- I_{-2} \oplus \epsilon_M I_5, \quad \epsilon_{\pm}, \epsilon_M \in \{\pm 1\}. \quad (57)$$

Parity, or compatibility with the real gravitational field, exchanges the two massless helicities and imposes $\epsilon_+ = \epsilon_-$. Even without adding parity to the covariance group, agreement with the free signature (7) fixes

$$\epsilon_+ = \epsilon_- = +1, \quad \epsilon_M = -1. \quad (58)$$

Proposition 8.1 (One-particle grading classification). *Within the stated covariant class, the free real form uniquely fixes*

$$J^{(1)} = I_2 \oplus (-I_5). \quad (59)$$

No linear covariant grading can assign different signs within the massive spin-2 multiplet or mix the massive and massless shells.

8.2 Canonical second quantization and cluster multiplicativity

We do not classify every Poincaré-covariant involution on a multiparticle Hilbert space: such an operator could act on momentum-dependent multiplicity spaces. The conventional lift is the natural second quantization $\Gamma(J^{(1)})$. Explicitly, we assume that it is diagonal in asymptotic particle labels, acts on symmetrized simple tensors by the tensor product of its one-particle actions, and is multiplicative under separated clusters. Equivalently, its value on a sector is a scalar $j(n_h, n_M) \in \{\pm 1\}$ depending only on particle numbers. These assumptions imply

$$j(n_h + n'_h, n_M + n'_M) = j(n_h, n_M)j(n'_h, n'_M), \quad j(0, 0) = 1. \quad (60)$$

A homomorphism from the free commutative monoid $\mathbb{N}^2$ is fixed by its values on the two generators. Equations (58) and (60) therefore give

$$\boxed{J_F = (-1)^{N_M}.} \quad (61)$$

Assigning independent signs to unrelated multiparticle sectors would violate (60) and hence cluster factorization.

Proposition 8.2 (Canonical multiplicative Fock lift). *Within the particle-number-diagonal, natural second-quantization class just specified, $J_F = (-1)^{N_M}$ is the unique lift of $J^{(1)} = I_2 \oplus (-I_5)$. No claim is made here about arbitrary momentum-dependent or non-factorizing multiparticle involutions.*

At the rational physical shell,

$$J_F |MM\rangle = +|MM\rangle, \quad J_F |Mh\rangle = -|Mh\rangle. \quad (62)$$

The transition crosses the two Krein signatures.

9 Krein visibility of the obstruction

For an operator on the positive-frame Hilbert representatives, define the Krein adjoint

$$X^\sharp = J_F X^\dagger J_F. \quad (63)$$

On the minimal ordered basis $(|MM\rangle, |Mh\rangle)$, $J_{\min} = \text{diag}(1, -1)$.

Consider first the forward block

$$X = i\mathcal{A}_K |Mh\rangle\langle MM|. \quad (64)$$

It is J_F -odd:

$$J_F X J_F = -X. \quad (65)$$

Its Krein adjoint and quadratic product are

$$\begin{aligned} X^\sharp &= -i\mathcal{A}_K J_F |MM\rangle\langle Mh| J_F = i\mathcal{A}_K |MM\rangle\langle Mh|, \\ X^\sharp X &= -\mathcal{A}_K^2 |MM\rangle\langle MM|. \end{aligned} \quad (66)$$

Consequently

$$\boxed{\text{Tr}(X^\sharp X) = -\mathcal{A}_K^2 \neq 0.} \quad (67)$$

The sign is indefinite, but the operator is not null.

For the off-diagonal positive-metric obstruction block

$$\mathcal{O} := \text{Off}_{if}(P_E S_2 P_E) = -2i\mathcal{A}_K \sigma_x, \quad (68)$$

one obtains

$$\boxed{\mathcal{O}^\sharp = \mathcal{O}, \quad \mathcal{O}^\sharp \mathcal{O} = -4\mathcal{A}_K^2 I_2, \quad \text{Tr}(\mathcal{O}^\sharp \mathcal{O}) = -8\mathcal{A}_K^2 \neq 0.} \quad (69)$$

Proposition 9.1 (Conventional Krein non-nullity). *The physical $MM \rightarrow Mh$ block and its off-diagonal metric obstruction are non-null for the canonical multiplicative fundamental symmetry (61). The obstruction is Krein-self-adjoint, indefinite, and visible to the finite-block quadratic trace.*

The algebraic distinction from a one-sided continuous grading is simple. For $\mathbb{Z}_2$,

$$1 + 1 = 0 \pmod{2}. \quad (70)$$

The adjoint of an odd operator is odd and their product is even. Thus oddness supplies no charge-null lemma:

$$\boxed{J_F\text{-odd} \not\Rightarrow \text{null}.} \quad (71)$$

By contrast, at the scalar $O(1,1)$ boundary a strictly one-sided nonzero continuous charge remains nonzero after the relevant product, and an invariant graded trace can kill it [26, 19].

Remark 9.2 (What is not ruled out). Equation (69) does not say that a Krein-self-adjoint interacting Hamiltonian cannot exist. Indeed, it displays Krein-self-adjointness of the minimal obstruction block. What fails is the stronger proposal that the conventional massive-number grading makes the branch-changing component null or supplies a positive generalized Born contribution. Indefinite pseudo-unitary evolution and a positive probability calculus are different questions.

10 No scalar-like charge-null mechanism

Could a continuous internal charge make the obstruction one-sided? Poincaré covariance first restricts any linear charge on the irreducible massive fiber to one scalar q_M . The free real graviton is neutral, $q_h = 0$. The verified nonzero interaction vertices impose

$$3q_M = 0 \quad (MMM), \quad 2q_M + q_h = 2q_M = 0 \quad (MMh). \quad (72)$$

Proposition 10.1 (Uniform abelian charge no-go). *There is no nontrivial uniform abelian charge assignment to the physical massive spin-2 irrep, with neutral graviton, that is respected by the Einstein–Weyl interaction.*

Proof. Equations (72) hold in any abelian charge group. Since $q_M = 3q_M - 2q_M$, they imply $q_M = 0$. The conclusion does not rely on torsion-freeness; $\gcd(2, 3) = 1$ eliminates finite torsion charges as well. $\square$

The MMM vertex has no real cubic decay shell but is a nonzero algebraic interaction vertex, so it already breaks massive-number parity at the action level. More decisively, the exact real-shell process changes N_M from 2 to 1 and proves

$$[(-1)^{N_M}, S] \neq 0 \quad (73)$$

on the physical scattering shell. Therefore the ingredients used to prove factorization simultaneously exclude an $O(1, 1)$ -like charge replacement.

11 BRST cohomology

The higher-derivative massive branch is a physical reduced mode and must not be confused with Faddeev–Popov ghosts. The external states in the four-point calculation are TT massive polarizations and TT massless graviton polarizations. The exact Ward identity, invariance under changes of gauge representative, axial/de Donder equality, and external inverse-propagator zeros show that the amplitude descends to reduced physical BRST cohomology.

Let Q denote the nilpotent BRST charge and let $|i\rangle, |f\rangle$ be closed physical representatives. If an operator were BRST-exact,

$$\mathcal{O} = \{Q, Y\}, \quad (74)$$

then, under the standard decoupling assumptions,

$$\langle f | \mathcal{O} | i \rangle = \langle f | QY | i \rangle + \langle f | YQ | i \rangle = 0. \quad (75)$$

The matrix element (54) is nonzero.

Proposition 11.1 (BRST survival). *The exact obstruction defines a nonzero operator on physical BRST cohomology and is not BRST-exact:*

$$[\mathcal{O}] \neq 0. \quad (76)$$

It cannot be placed in the standard BRST-null ideal.

This proposition concerns the induced operator on physical cohomology. We do not construct an extension of J_F to the complete gauge-fixed Fock space of Faddeev–Popov ghosts and contractible sectors; accordingly we do not call J_F a full-space BRST-compatible fundamental symmetry.

Appendix G records the finite-complex algebra checked by the verification suite. In a splitting into physical cohomology and a contractible doublet, the physical-to-physical block of $\{Q, Y\}$ vanishes for a completely general Y , while the physical obstruction block survives unchanged.

12 Master theorem

Theorem 12.1 (Interacting completion obstruction). *Let scalar-free Einstein–Weyl gravity (1) be in its regular split phase about flat space. Use the covariant free completion classes of Paper IV and the analytic metric-deformation class of Paper V. Then:*

1. the Lorentz-covariant positive pseudo-Hermitian completion is protected at first perturbative order, $\mathfrak{o}_+^{(1)} = 0$;
2. at second order the physical process $MM \rightarrow Mh$ generates the nonzero shell obstruction (54);
3. hence the canonical Paper-IV positive base metric has no analytic second-order deformation for the complete tree-level cubic and quartic Einstein–Weyl vertex content;
4. on physical BRST cohomology, the free one-particle real form has the canonical particle-number-diagonal, natural and cluster-multiplicative lift $J_F = (-1)^{N_M}$;
5. for this grading the obstruction is non-null, $\text{Tr}(\mathcal{O}^\sharp \mathcal{O}) = -8\mathcal{A}_K^2 \neq 0$, and survives physical BRST cohomology; and
6. the nonzero MMM and MMh vertices prohibit a nontrivial uniform abelian charge grading analogous to the scalar $O(1,1)$ mechanism.

Thus, through second tree order, neither the canonical analytic metric deformation nor the conventional massive-number null mechanism supplies a positive-probability completion in the stated classes.

Proof. Item 1 is Theorem 4.3. Items 2 and 3 are Theorem 7.2, independently supported by the factorization Proposition 5.1 and the Born–deformation identity (14). Item 4 is Propositions 8.1 and 8.2. Item 5 is Propositions 9.1 and 11.1. Item 6 is Proposition 10.1. $\square$

13 Scope and nonclaims

The hypotheses in Theorem 12.1 are part of the result. The paper rules out:

- analytic deformation through second order of the canonical Paper-IV Lorentz-covariant positive base metric by the complete tree-level cubic and quartic vertex content;
- a conserved naive massive-number ghost parity;
- conventional covariant linear one-particle fundamental symmetries that agree with the free real form but differ on selected massive helicities;
- independent particle-number-sector signs within the natural, cluster-multiplicative scalar Fock-lift class;
- a uniform abelian continuous- or torsion-charge null mechanism compatible with the verified vertices; and
- standard BRST-exact nullity of the physical obstruction.

It does *not* prove:

- that no nonperturbative or differently pointed positive completion exists;
- that the full interacting Hamiltonian has complex energies;

- that every nonlocal or non-factorizing grading fails;
- that no momentum-dependent Poincaré-covariant involution exists on multiparticle multiplicity spaces;
- that the cohomological grading J_F necessarily extends to a fundamental symmetry on the complete gauge-fixed BRST complex;
- that no singular $M \rightarrow 0$ or conformal-boundary completion can be defined;
- that a Maldacena-type boundary truncation of the solution algebra is inconsistent [20];
or
- that the result extends unchanged to quadratic gravities with a scalaron, matter, cosmological constant, or a different background.

Two prominent prescriptions lie outside the assumptions for a particularly concrete reason. In the unstable-resonance treatment of Donoghue and Menezes [12], the massive ghostlike pole does not belong to the asymptotic spectrum and only stable states enter the unitarity sum. In the fakeon construction [13], the massive mode is purely virtual and amplitudes are defined by a nonanalytic continuation. The present theorem instead puts physical M states on both sides of the scattering process and studies an analytic metric deformation. It therefore neither refutes nor subsumes either prescription.

Any surviving null-sector construction must therefore leave the conventional class. Possibilities include a grading singular at the conformal boundary, a nonlinear mixing of asymptotic particle sectors, a nonlocal observable algebra, a failure of ordinary cluster factorization, or boundary conditions that remove part of the fourth-order solution space. These are qualitatively different from a straightforward gravitational lift of the Bateman–Turok mechanism.

There is now a second, logically independent reason that such a lift cannot be called straightforward. The exact scalar continuation recorded in the updated artifact of Paper V [26] proves, with dependency tag `REDUCED-MODE`, that the complete final-state collinear real normalization response does not cancel the virtual external-mass logarithm under any continuous axis-compatible parent/daughter gluing, including the physical pair threshold. This does not transfer the scalar coefficient or obstruction to gravity. It identifies an additional construction that a gravitational completion would need independently: a distributional normalization, degenerate or dressed asymptotic states, or a resummation prescription defined on the gravitational BRST carrier. The corrected scalar certificate `REVERSE_PHYSICS_BT_ASYMPTOTIC_GENERATOR_PREFLIGHT_V1` now gives an exact finite witness for the dressed alternative. After division by the scalar Born rate, projector idempotence forces dimensionless hard and three-pair blocks $-1/16$ and $+1/16$; multiplying back gives the physical $-3/512$ normalization against the scalar real response. The same certificate shows that the ordinary single-denominator cubic Fock generator vanishes in the massless collinear limit, so a Jordan/distributional asymptotic term is required. A scalar successor, `REVERSE_PHYSICS_BT_RT_JORDAN_KERNEL_V1`, now derives the resonant two-annihilator part of that term from the published composite map. After a declared repair of an internal Appendix C oscillator-label inconsistency, its apparent t, t^2 growth cancels exactly on the (Ω, Υ) carrier and a formal finite-mode anti-Krein generator exists. The resulting Krein Gram has cubic splitting-endpoint poles, so its distributional continuum domain, oscillatory sectors, and the target $1/48$ remain open. Gravity would still require an

independent BRST-compatible construction rather than importing either scalar coefficients or this reduced-mode endpoint obstruction. The scalar endpoint extension is now additionally known to retain three reflection-even local constants; distinct exact plus and cutoff prescriptions disagree even on the inclusive constant test. Hence neither scalar symmetry nor the interior kernel selects the target coefficient without the omitted oscillatory and squeezed sectors, and no such ambiguity may be imported as a gravitational normalization. The scalar oscillatory and squeezed sectors are also ruled out as the missing normalization source: both lie in the strictly negative BT charge radical and are trace-null. Conversely, the free cross-CCR and projection idempotence force the scalar coisometric support to be the identity to every formal order. The remaining scalar canonical identities are now also known to be insufficient selectors. The exact certificate `REVERSE_PHYSICS_BT_CANONICAL_ENDPOINT_AMBIGUITY_V1` constructs a three-parameter canonical/projector countermodel in the endpoint carrier: hard and endpoint trace shifts cancel for arbitrary parameters, and $1/48$ is compatible but not derived. This is not a claim that all parameters occur in the actual BT transport; it isolates the deferred continuum map or an independent physical endpoint condition as the missing scalar datum. It is not a range defect or phase prescription that gravity could copy. The subsequent scalar certificate `REVERSE_PHYSICS_BT_FULL_OFF_RESONANT_PROJECTOR_V1` retains the exact parent–daughter energy deficit and restores the full radial daughter measure. The repaired carrier has no surviving t, t^2 powers and restricts exactly to the resonant kernel, but its universal soft cross-Gram is $-1/(2r^3)$. Multiplication by $r^2 dr$ leaves $-(1/2)dr/r$, whose finite part shifts by $(1/2)\log c$ under a common cutoff rescaling. Thus full phase space reduces the collinear three-jet ambiguity to one soft normalization on the declared chart without selecting it. A scalar soft-collinear asymptotic Hamiltonian or hard matching operator with cancelling regulator response is the next gate. This is only a `LOCAL-ALGEBRAIC, REDUCED-MODE` classification; it is not a graviton/BRST transfer, a complete probability, or a `LORENTZIAN-CAUSAL` result. There is nevertheless now a genuine scalar hard-scattering baseline. The certificate `REVERSE_PHYSICS_BT_UV_HARD_SCATTERING_LAW_V1` proves at leading logarithmic order that every fixed nonforward scalar acceptance falls as $24\pi^2/[25s\log^2(s/\Lambda^2)]$ per unit solid angle. This uses the scalar Born normalization, scalar beta function, and scalar projected hard log. None of its coefficient, positivity statement, or Callan–Symanzik closure transfers to the graviton/BRST carrier; the gravity paper records it only as the kind of physical endpoint an independent gravitational construction would have to reach.

14 Discussion

14.1 The same order pattern, for different reasons

Paper V and the present gravity calculation share the sequence

$$\text{first-order protection} \longrightarrow \text{second-order scattering obstruction.} \quad (77)$$

The agreement in order should not obscure the difference in structure. The perfect-square scalar is protected by its special cubic kinematic factor and reality assignments. Gravity is protected because the Einstein solution space is an exact nonlinear subsector and the remaining odd cubic vertex is kinematically closed. In the scalar, an enhanced $O(1,1)$ charge appears exactly at the perfect-square boundary and can sort an obstruction into a one-sided null ideal.

In gravity, the MMM and MMh interactions remove every uniform abelian charge before the four-point obstruction is considered.

14.2 Relation to the PT-symmetric quadratic-gravity proposal

Kuntz [9] starts from the same scalar-free Einstein–Weyl vertex content used here. His auxiliary-field complex deformation makes the massless and massive free spin-2 sectors Hermitian and positive and places factors of i on interactions with an odd number of massive fields. At this level his rotation and (6) are the same construction up to the sign chosen for the quarter-turn. His transverse physical asymptotic space also retains both massless helicities and all five massive polarizations, so the distinction is not that the M states have been removed.

The difference is in the interacting test. The displayed metric calculation in Ref. [9] replaces the full tensor field theory by a mode Hamiltonian with spin and momentum dependence suppressed and with schematic interaction coefficients. It demonstrates a positive perturbative metric for that truncation and offers it as evidence for the gravitational theory, but it does not include the exact energy-degenerate $MM \rightarrow Mh$ block. Proposition 2.1 shows why that omission is decisive: a nonzero anti-Hermitian component inside a degenerate free-energy block is not divided by a free-energy difference and cannot be removed by an analytic R_2 .

Thus our result is a direct full-vertex stress test of that proposal, not a general rejection of PT-symmetric gravity. Any extension of the truncated construction to the complete theory must evade (54) by leaving at least one of the present hypotheses: for example through a nonanalytic metric, a different free base point, different asymptotic states, or a prescription that excludes the massive mode from the physical scattering spectrum.

14.3 Real forms become dynamical

At the free level a real form selects which complex solutions are called real and which adjoint defines observables. The choice can appear kinematic. The phase theorem makes its interacting content explicit: every physical process with odd external massive number crosses the two reality assignments and becomes anti-Hermitian in the positive frame. The decisive diagnostic is therefore

$$\boxed{\text{Which physical on-shell processes change the real-form sector?}} \quad (78)$$

For Einstein–Weyl gravity the first answer is $MM \rightarrow Mh$.

14.4 Why the factorization and physical rails are both useful

The Einstein-frame residue (38) is compact, independent, and immune to cancellation by local contact terms. It proves a genuine interaction before the large quartic calculation is attempted. The original-variable physical point then supplies what factorization alone does not: an exact real-shell value, the full gauge cancellation, the physical adjoint, and the deformation-complex matrix element. Agreement between the two rails is substantially stronger than either calculation in isolation.

14.5 What Krein visibility means

The negative traces in (67) and (69) are not advertised as negative probabilities. They show that the conventional quadratic Krein form sees the block: it is neither zero nor killed by a

grading selection rule. A viable interacting probability construction would need extra structure beyond the free fundamental symmetry. The scalar boundary supplies a continuous one-sided charge at tree level, but the exact scalar loop audit shows that this algebraic structure alone does not select an ordinary axis-compatible infrared prescription. The corrected finite scalar projector transport shows that coherent cross-multiplicity normalization is algebraically compatible after Born-rate normalization, while the ordinary cubic Fock generator has zero collinear Gram; it does not by itself show that the required Jordan term exists. The exact scalar successor now derives its two-annihilator coefficient and proves secular cancellation, but stops at a cubic endpoint-pole obstruction before a continuum projector or probability exists. The verified Einstein–Weyl vertices do not even supply the corresponding uniform charge, and no gravitational infrared completion is constructed here.

The immediate research problem is consequently no longer another scalar doubling. It is to understand whether conformal-boundary conditions, changed observable algebras, or genuinely nonlocal gravitational structures can evade the hypotheses of Theorem 12.1 without destroying covariance and factorization. Any proposal that retains massless asymptotic gravitons must additionally declare how its real and virtual collinear sectors are glued and prove regulator independence on the BRST quotient; the scalar certificate motivates this gate but is not evidence that gravity passes or fails it.

References

- [1] K. S. Stelle, *Renormalization of higher-derivative quantum gravity*, Phys. Rev. D **16** (1977) 953, [doi:10.1103/physrevd.16.953](https://doi.org/10.1103/physrevd.16.953).
- [2] A. Salvio, *Quadratic gravity*, Front. Phys. **6** (2018) 77, arXiv:1804.09944.
- [3] A. Hindawi, B. A. Ovrut and D. Waldram, *Consistent spin-two coupling and quadratic gravitation*, Phys. Rev. D **53** (1996) 5583–5596, arXiv:hep-th/9509142.
- [4] G. Magnano and L. M. Sokolowski, *Nonlinear massive spin-two field generated by higher derivative gravity*, Ann. Phys. **306** (2003) 1–35, arXiv:gr-qc/0209022.
- [5] P. Donà, S. Giaccari, L. Modesto, L. Rachwał and Y. Zhu, *Scattering amplitudes in super-renormalizable gravity*, JHEP **08** (2015) 038, arXiv:1506.04589.
- [6] A. Mostafazadeh, *Metric operator in pseudo-Hermitian quantum mechanics and the imaginary cubic potential*, J. Phys. A **39** (2006) 10171–10188, arXiv:quant-ph/0508195.
- [7] C. M. Bender, D. C. Brody and H. F. Jones, *Extension of PT-symmetric quantum mechanics to quantum field theory with cubic interaction*, Phys. Rev. D **70** (2004) 025001, arXiv:hep-th/0402183.
- [8] J. Kubo and J. Kuntz, *Analysis of unitarity in conformal quantum gravity*, Class. Quantum Grav. **39** (2022) 175010, arXiv:2202.08298.
- [9] J. Kuntz, *Unitarity through PT symmetry in quantum quadratic gravity*, arXiv:2410.08278.
- [10] T. Adamo, S. Nakach and A. A. Tseytlin, *Scattering of conformal higher spin fields*, JHEP **07** (2018) 016, arXiv:1805.00394.

- [11] H. Johansson, G. Mogull and F. Teng, *Unraveling conformal gravity amplitudes*, JHEP **09** (2018) 080, arXiv:1806.05124.
- [12] J. F. Donoghue and G. Menezes, *Unitarity, stability and loops of unstable ghosts*, Phys. Rev. D **100** (2019) 105006, arXiv:1908.02416.
- [13] D. Anselmi, *Fakeons and Lee–Wick models*, JHEP **02** (2018) 141, arXiv:1801.00915.
- [14] H.-S. Liu, H. Lü, C. N. Pope and J. F. Vázquez-Poritz, *Not conformally-Einstein metrics in conformal gravity*, arXiv:1303.5781.
- [15] S. Kamefuchi, L. O’Raifeartaigh and A. Salam, *Change of variables and equivalence theorems in quantum field theories*, Nucl. Phys. **28** (1961) 529–549, doi:10.1016/0029-5582(61)90056-6.
- [16] S. Weinberg, *The Quantum Theory of Fields, Vol. I: Foundations*, Cambridge University Press, 1995.
- [17] C. M. Bender and P. D. Mannheim, *No-ghost theorem for the fourth-order derivative Pais–Uhlenbeck oscillator model*, Phys. Rev. Lett. **100** (2008) 110402, doi:10.1103/physrevlett.100.110402.
- [18] C. M. Bender and P. D. Mannheim, *Exactly solvable PT-symmetric Hamiltonian having no Hermitian counterpart*, Phys. Rev. D **78** (2008) 025022, arXiv:0804.4190.
- [19] S. Bateman and N. Turok, *Escape from Ostrogradsky via hidden ghost parity*, arXiv:2607.00096.
- [20] J. Maldacena, *Einstein gravity from conformal gravity*, arXiv:1105.5632.
- [21] T. Ya. Azizov and I. S. Iokhvidov, *Linear Operators in Spaces with an Indefinite Metric*, Wiley, 1989.
- [22] GPT-5.6.sol and A. A. Palm, *Canonical Positive Symplectic Diagonalization of the Pais–Uhlenbeck Oscillator*, Paper I of the pure-Weyl gravity programme, 2026; file paper/01-symplectic-diagonalization.pdf in the repository <https://github.com/area9innovation/weyl-gravity>.
- [23] GPT-5.6.sol and A. A. Palm, *The Pais–Uhlenbeck Metric as a Minimum-Distortion Principle, and the Representation Problem for the Fourth-Order Field*, Paper II of the pure-Weyl gravity programme, 2026; file paper/02-variational-fock.pdf in the repository <https://github.com/area9innovation/weyl-gravity>.
- [24] GPT-5.6.sol and A. A. Palm, *The Universal Vacuum of the Fourth-Order Scalar Field: Metric Orbits, Fock Sectors, and the Krein Boundary*, Paper III of the pure-Weyl gravity programme, 2026; file paper/03-fourth-order-vacuum.pdf in the repository <https://github.com/area9innovation/weyl-gravity>.
- [25] GPT-5.6.sol and A. A. Palm, *Gauge Reduction and the Completion Problem in Fourth-Order Gravity: PU Pairing, Covariant Real Forms, and the Conformal Jordan Boundary*, Paper IV of the pure-Weyl gravity programme, 2026;

file `paper/04-fourth-order-gravity.pdf` in the repository <https://github.com/area9innovation/weyl-gravity>.

- [26] GPT-5.6.sol and A. A. Palm, *Interaction Obstructions, Resonant PT Breaking, and Doubled Jordan Symmetry in Fourth-Order Theories*, Paper V of the pure-Weyl gravity programme, 2026; file `paper/05-interaction-obstructions.pdf` in the repository <https://github.com/area9innovation/weyl-gravity>.

A Einstein consistent truncation and LSZ

This appendix spells out the hypotheses behind Lemma 4.1. For the scalar-free combination in (1), the field equation is the Einstein tensor plus a multiple of the Bach tensor. In four dimensions the Bach tensor may be written

$$B_{\mu\nu} = \left(\nabla^\rho \nabla^\sigma + \frac{1}{2} R^{\rho\sigma} \right) C_{\mu\rho\nu\sigma} \quad (79)$$

up to a convention-dependent overall sign. It vanishes on every Einstein metric [14]. In the flat-background problem the relevant exact subsector is Ricci-flat vacuum Einstein gravity.

On the regular branch of the Legendre transformation from Ricci-tensor gravity to its second-order form, introduce the Einstein metric and a symmetric massive field $\Phi_{\mu\nu}$. The transformation is algebraic in the auxiliary variables and locally invertible wherever its determinant does not vanish [4]. Linearization about the common flat vacuum diagonalizes the asymptotic equations into

$$\mathcal{K}_h h = 0, \quad \mathcal{K}_M M = 0, \quad (80)$$

with $p^2 = 0$ and $p^2 = M^2$, respectively. Thus h and M used in the main text are LSZ mass eigenfields, not arbitrary components of the original metric perturbation.

Let $E_M[h, M] = 0$ be the exact massive-field equation in this frame. The consistent truncation states

$$E_M[h_E, 0] = 0 \quad (81)$$

for every nonlinear Einstein solution h_E . Expanding about flat space,

$$E_M[h, M] = \mathcal{K}_M M + \sum_{n \geq 2} J_M^{(n)}[h^n] + \sum_{r \geq 1, s \geq 1} J_{r,s}[M^r h^s]. \quad (82)$$

Equation (81) does not require each off-shell functional $J_M^{(n)}$ to vanish. It requires its value on a full perturbative Einstein solution to cancel, including nonlinear corrections to that solution. LSZ amputation removes precisely the external inverse-propagator and field-redefinition terms, leaving

$$\mathcal{A}(M, h_1, \dots, h_n) = 0 \quad (83)$$

for physical on-shell Einstein gravitons. This is the standard consistent-truncation selection rule.

The perturbator supplies an explicit cubic check. In signature $(+, -, -, -)$, take all momenta incoming,

$$p_M = (1, 0, 0, 0), \quad p_2 = \left(-\frac{1}{2}, 0, 0, -\frac{1}{2} \right), \quad p_3 = \left(-\frac{1}{2}, 0, 0, \frac{1}{2} \right). \quad (84)$$

They obey $p_M^2 = 1$, $p_2^2 = p_3^2 = 0$ and sum to zero. The exact action coefficient vanishes for all five massive TT polarizations and the four products of the two graviton helicities. Replacing either graviton polarization by $p_{(\mu}\xi_{\nu)}$ also gives zero.

The selection rule is tree-level and concerns external mass eigenfields. It does not state that the original fourth-order metric action lacks terms apparently linear in a chosen massive component, nor does it exclude loop effects, anomalies, or a singular failure of the mass-eigenfield map at the conformal boundary.

B Einstein-frame cubic expansion

We record enough of the independent G14 calculation to make the exact numbers reproducible. This appendix uses signature $(-, +, +, +)$ and $M = 1$. It matches `symbolic/verify_gravity_factorization.py`.

For a symmetric matrix Φ , write

$$X = g^{-1}\Phi, \quad t_n = \text{tr}(X^n), \quad A = \sqrt{\det(I + X)}. \quad (85)$$

Through cubic order,

$$\begin{aligned} A &= 1 + \frac{1}{2}t_1 + \frac{1}{8}t_1^2 - \frac{1}{4}t_2 + \frac{1}{48}t_1^3 - \frac{1}{8}t_1t_2 + \frac{1}{6}t_3 + O(\Phi^4), \\ A^{-1} &= 1 - (A - 1) + (A - 1)^2 - (A - 1)^3 + O(\Phi^4). \end{aligned} \quad (86)$$

In the potential of (29), $\tau = 4 + t_1$ and the relevant quadratic contraction is $4 + 2t_1 + t_2$. Substitution gives, when $t_1 = 0$,

$$A^{-1}(-\tau^2 + \psi_{\mu\nu}\psi^{\mu\nu} + 6A\tau - 12A^2) = t_2 + O(\Phi^4), \quad (87)$$

with zero t_3 coefficient. This is the potential cancellation (31).

At first order in one plane wave (p, E) ,

$$Q^{(1)\alpha}{}_{\mu\nu}(E, p) = \frac{i}{2}\eta^{\alpha\beta}(p_\mu E_{\beta\nu} + p_\nu E_{\beta\mu} - p_\beta E_{\mu\nu}). \quad (88)$$

The quadratic correction $Q^{(2)}$ comes from the inverse- ψ factor. The cubic MMM coefficient is the sum of all contractions $K(Q^{(1)}, Q^{(2)}) + K(Q^{(2)}, Q^{(1)})$, with the factor $1/2$ in (29). Exact substitution of (32) and normalized TT tensors gives (33).

For MMh , the script expands g^{-1} , ψ^{-1} , the connection of g , and Q through the orders required for the coefficient of three independent wave labels. At (34), take

$$v_r = (1, -1, 0, 0), \quad e_h = (1, 0, 0, 1), \quad E_r = v_r^b \otimes v_r^b, \quad H = e_h^b \otimes e_h^b. \quad (89)$$

Together with the internal $+$ polarization at rest these tensors are transverse and traceless, and the coefficient is (35). For

$$H_{\mu\nu}^{\text{gauge}} = k_\mu \xi_\nu + k_\nu \xi_\mu \quad (90)$$

with four independent symbolic components of ξ , the coefficient vanishes identically.

Finally, the massive TT two-point coefficient for waves (p, E) and $(-p, E)$ with $E \cdot E = 1$ is

$$L_M^{(2)} = \frac{p^2 + 1}{4}. \quad (91)$$

This fixes the factor of four between the polarization numerator $\sqrt{3}/32$ and pole residue $\sqrt{3}/8$; it is not inferred from a unit-residue completeness convention.

C Polarization basis and factorization sum

At the rest momentum $P = (1, 0, 0, 0)$ in the Einstein-frame signature, let e_x, e_y, e_z be unit spatial vectors. A normalized massive basis is

$$\begin{aligned} E_+ &= \frac{1}{\sqrt{2}}(e_x e_x - e_y e_y), & E_\times &= \frac{1}{\sqrt{2}}(e_x e_y + e_y e_x), \\ E_0 &= \frac{1}{\sqrt{6}}(e_x e_x + e_y e_y - 2e_z e_z), & E_{xz} &= \frac{1}{\sqrt{2}}(e_x e_z + e_z e_x), \\ & & E_{yz} &= \frac{1}{\sqrt{2}}(e_y e_z + e_z e_y). \end{aligned} \quad (92)$$

Each is transverse, traceless, and orthonormal under the induced tensor inner product. For a massive momentum $(E, 0, 0, p_z)$, replace e_z by the normalized longitudinal transverse vector; the same formulas give the transported helicity basis.

The factorization numerator is basis-independent. In a nonorthonormal basis T_a with Gram matrix $G_{ab} = T_a \cdot T_b$, it is

$$N = V_a (G^{-1})^{ab} U_b, \quad (93)$$

where $V_a = \mathcal{A}_3(M, M, T_a)$ and $U_b = \mathcal{A}_3(T_b, M, h)$. The orthonormal basis above reduces this to the sum displayed after (36). All five intermediate states are included; the result is not one selected nonzero channel.

The original fourth-order perturbiner supplies a separate complex factorization check at a rational- i point. It constructs an exact five-dimensional TT basis at the internal massive momentum, contracts the two cubic vectors with its Gram inverse, and obtains a nonzero reduced numerator. The Einstein-frame calculation then fixes a compact normalized representative and the explicit inverse-kernel slope.

D Physical-shell geometry and the rational point

For incoming equal masses in the center-of-mass frame,

$$p_1 = (E, 0, 0, p), \quad p_2 = (E, 0, 0, -p), \quad E = \frac{\sqrt{s}}{2}, \quad p = \frac{1}{2}\sqrt{s - 4M^2}. \quad (94)$$

Choose the outgoing graviton at scattering angle θ ,

$$k = (\kappa, \kappa \sin \theta, 0, \kappa \cos \theta), \quad \kappa = \frac{s - M^2}{2\sqrt{s}}, \quad (95)$$

and $p_3 = p_1 + p_2 - k$. Then $p_3^2 = M^2$ and $p_3^0 = (s + M^2)/(2\sqrt{s})$. The domain

$$s > 4M^2, \quad -1 < \cos \theta < 1 \quad (96)$$

is a real open chart away from forward/backward and threshold degeneracies.

At $s = 25M^2/4$ one has $E = 5M/4$ and $\kappa = 21M/20$. Taking $\cos \theta = 3/5$ and $\sin \theta = 4/5$ gives exactly (40). All energy, momentum, and mass-shell identities are rational. Because all spatial y components vanish, reflection $y \mapsto -y$ is a symmetry. An odd number of y -odd polarization tensors forces an amplitude zero. The certificate uses the first nonzero all-even combination.

The exact threshold regression uses two incoming massive particles at rest and an outgoing graviton of energy $3M/4$. In the separate polarization convention of that test,

$$\mathcal{A}_{\text{threshold}} = -\frac{509784}{390625}. \quad (97)$$

Threshold is not used for the open-set claim; it guards the implementation against later changes.

E Full four-point engine and deformation certificate

E.1 Wave algebra

A wave-algebra element is a dictionary from subsets of external labels to sparse tensor components. Multiplication discards products in which a wave label repeats, so multilinear truncation is automatic. A derivative acting on subset S multiplies by

$$iP_{S\mu} = i \sum_{a \in S} p_{a\mu}. \quad (98)$$

From the metric, inverse metric, determinant, Christoffel symbols, and Ricci tensor, the engine extracts

$$\sqrt{-g}R, \quad \sqrt{-g}R_{\mu\nu}R^{\mu\nu}, \quad \sqrt{-g}R^2 \quad (99)$$

at the desired wave subset. Before any cubic or quartic claim it checks that the two-point coefficient vanishes on $p^2 = 0$ and $p^2 = M^2$, is nonzero off shell, and obeys cubic Ward identities.

E.2 Exact polarization tensors

For a massive momentum p in the (t, x, z) plane, choose two independent transverse in-plane vectors v_1, v_2 . With

$$\Pi_{\mu\nu} = \eta_{\mu\nu} - \frac{p_\mu p_\nu}{M^2}, \quad (100)$$

the parity-even TT tensor used in the certificate is

$$E_{12,\mu\nu} = v_{1\mu}v_{2\nu} + v_{2\mu}v_{1\nu} - \frac{2}{3}(v_1 \cdot v_2)\Pi_{\mu\nu}. \quad (101)$$

The three massive external legs use the corresponding E_{12} at $p_1, p_2, -p_3$. For the graviton momentum direction proportional to $(5, 4, 0, 3)$, use transverse vectors

$$e_1 = (0, -3, 0, 4), \quad e_2 = (0, 0, 1, 0), \quad (102)$$

and the real plus tensor

$$\varepsilon_+ = \frac{1}{25}e_1e_1 - e_2e_2. \quad (103)$$

These are the convention-fixed polarizations entering (43).

E.3 Gauge and adjoint checks

For each exchange, the exact bordered solution obeys

$$CX = 0, \quad KX + C^T \lambda + J = 0. \quad (104)$$

The total amplitude with graviton gauge polarization is zero, while the contact contribution alone is

$$-\frac{596335802837691}{361367187500000} \neq 0. \quad (105)$$

This cancellation is a sensitive check of relative signs and combinatorics. De Donder and axial constraints give identical physical totals.

Under reversal $p_a \mapsto -p_a$, all contacts and cubic currents are recomputed. The action contains two- and four-derivative terms, and the independently recomputed quadratic matrices obey $K(-P) = K(P)$. Contact, s , t , and u pieces equal their forward values separately. Since the external linear tensors are real, this is the physical reverse matrix element used in $\mathcal{B}_{2,+}^\dagger$.

E.4 Pole regression

An exact shell-preserving complex shift

$$p_1(z) = p_1 + z\eta, \quad k(z) = k - z\eta, \quad \eta = (3, 0, 4i, 5), \quad (106)$$

has $\eta^2 = \eta \cdot p_1 = \eta \cdot k = 0$. In the relevant channel

$$P(z)^2 = \frac{25}{4} + 15z \quad (107)$$

hits the massive pole at $z_* = -7/20$. The bordered kernel there has exactly the five TT zero modes. If T collects them and G_5 is their Gram matrix,

$$W = T^T K'(z_*) T = -\frac{15}{2} G_5 \quad (108)$$

entrywise, including 24 nontrivial identities. The residue

$$-j_1^T W^{-1} j_2 = -\frac{4551434384 i}{328515625} \neq 0 \quad (109)$$

equals the independently normalized cubic contraction divided by the kinetic slope. A direct near-pole numerical probe of the actual bordered exchange agrees to relative error below 10^{-4} . This regression is not used to set the convention of the compact Einstein-frame residue; it validates the original-variable propagator machinery.

F Covariant grading and Fock-lift equations

The exact grading check solves the commutant rather than assuming Schur's lemma numerically. At a standard massive momentum, represent the spin-2 fiber by symmetric traceless 3×3 tensors. The three $SO(3)$ generators act as

$$J_i(T) = L_i T + T L_i^T. \quad (110)$$

Solving $[X, J_i] = 0$ for a general 5×5 matrix gives $X = a_M I_5$. On the two complex massless helicity fibers, the little- group rotation generator is $\text{diag}(2, -2)$, whose commutant is diagonal. Solving simultaneously with the mass Casimir on the full seven-dimensional fiber gives

$$X = \text{diag}(a_+, a_-, a_M I_5). \quad (111)$$

Hermiticity and $X^2 = I$ restrict the three scalars to signs. The helicity-exchange real structure sets $a_+ = a_-$; the free signature fixes $(a_+, a_-, a_M) = (1, 1, -1)$.

For the Fock lift, cluster factorization is the monoid equation (60). Iterating it gives

$$j(n_h, n_M) = j(1, 0)^{n_h} j(0, 1)^{n_M} = (-1)^{n_M}. \quad (112)$$

The exact script verifies multiplicativity for all partitions in a finite table and the analytic monoid argument establishes it for all particle numbers.

G BRST block and non-nullity

The finite verification sets the common real external normalization $\eta_{\text{conv}} \mathcal{N}_{fi}$ to one and therefore uses $\mathcal{A}_K^{\text{red}}$ in place of $\mathcal{A}_K$. Restoring the nonzero multiplier rescales every quadratic trace by its square and cannot change nullity.

The minimal non-null calculation uses

$$J_{\min} = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ 0 & -1 \end{pmatrix}, \quad X = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 0 \\ i\mathcal{A}_K & 0 \end{pmatrix}. \quad (113)$$

Then

$$X^\sharp = J_{\min} X^\dagger J_{\min} = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & i\mathcal{A}_K \\ 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}, \quad X^\sharp X = \begin{pmatrix} -\mathcal{A}_K^2 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}. \quad (114)$$

For $\mathcal{O} = -2i\mathcal{A}_K \sigma_x$,

$$J_{\min} \mathcal{O}^\dagger J_{\min} = \mathcal{O}, \quad \mathcal{O}^2 = -4\mathcal{A}_K^2 I. \quad (115)$$

To encode the cohomology argument, take a canonical finite splitting into two physical representatives and one contractible doublet $u \mapsto v \mapsto 0$. In the ordered basis (i, f, u, v) ,

$$Q = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 0 \end{pmatrix}, \quad Q^2 = 0. \quad (116)$$

For a completely general 4×4 matrix Y , direct multiplication shows

$$(QY + YQ)_{\text{phys,phys}} = 0. \quad (117)$$

The upper-left physical block of the exact obstruction is nonzero after embedding, so it cannot be of this exact form. This finite matrix is not a replacement for gravitational BRST quantization; it records the universal algebraic implication used after the Ward and reduced-helicity checks have established that the amplitude descends to cohomology.

H Machine-verification index

All scripts named below are in `symbolic/` and print ALL PASS. Checks use SymPy exact arithmetic except for the explicitly labelled near-pole regression.

Archive. The engine, polarization data and manuscript sources are archived in a GitHub repository:

<https://github.com/area9innovation/weyl-gravity>.

The historical pre-extraction verification snapshot was

`aeb9acaa944f53cbf29fba37476bfe888c6a1ddd`

in the former monorepo; current paths are relative to the standalone repository root.

Environment. The recorded versions are Python 3.14.4 and SymPy 1.14.0. The pinned dependency and the SHA-256 manifest are, respectively,

`symbolic/paper6-requirements.txt`
`symbolic/paper6-verification.sha256`.

Momentum, signature, polarization, action and reduced-amplitude conventions are recorded in Appendices B–E; they are explicit script inputs rather than hidden generated defaults.

Check	Claim	Artifact/type
G13a–b	two-point on-shell validation and cubic Ward identities	<code>gravity_perturbiner.py</code> , exact
G13	$Mhh = 0$ for 5×4 physical polarization choices	<code>verify_gravity_cubic.py</code> , exact
G14a–c	nonzero original-variable MMM , MMh , and reduced massive-pole factorization	<code>verify_gravity_cubic.py</code> , exact
G14d–i	potential cancellation, compact $-\sqrt{6}/8$ and $-\sqrt{2}/8$ amplitudes, symbolic Ward identity, five-state sum, inverse kernel	<code>verify_gravity_factorization.py</code> , exact
G15a–f	full physical contact+ s, t, u , Ward, Bose, gauge, and threshold checks	<code>verify_gravity_g15.py</code> , exact
G15g	shifted-pole kernel, Schur slope, residue; near-pole probe	same script, exact plus numerical regression
G16	crossing needed for the adjoint is included in G17; exhaustive 250-polarization scan is deferred	not a theorem dependency
G17a–d	exposed contact/exchanges, reverse process, EOM/Ward/gauge, termwise quarter-turn	<code>verify_gravity_obstruction.py</code> , exact
G17e–g	exact shell obstruction, first-order metric-ambiguity independence, and Born-deformation identity	same script, exact
G18a–b	one-particle commutant and cluster-factorizing Fock lift	<code>verify_gravity_krein.py</code> , exact
G18c–e	non-null quadratic traces, charge no-go, and BRST block	same script, exact

The analytic inputs not reducible to finite symbolic identities are identified in the main text: the induced-representation interpretation of the free commutant (Paper IV), the consistent-truncation/LSZ argument, covariant-stationary tree matching, real-analytic continuation on the physical shell, and the standard BRST decoupling statement. The symbolic checks test every convention-sensitive coefficient consumed by those arguments.

Reproduction commands. From the repository root for this project:

```
python3 symbolic/verify_gravity_paper6.py
```

The expected terminal line is PAPER VI GRAVITY SUITE: ALL PASS. The optional `--quick` flag skips the slower shifted-pole regression; the theorem-critical obstruction script independently recomputes the exact physical certificate. Individual script outputs remain the canonical coefficient-level audit trail mapped in the table above.